This Parisian classic is given extra punch with a spoonful of brandy in every bowl. Serve it the moment you've made it—French onion soup is best piping hot.

french onion soup

SERVES 4 **PREP** 10 MINS **COOK** 1 HR 20 MINS **FREEZE** UP TO 1 MONTH
WITHOUT THE CROÛTES AND CHEESE

2 tbsp butter
1 tbsp sunflower oil
1½lb (675g) onions, thinly sliced
1 tsp sugar
salt and freshly ground black pepper
½ cup red wine
2 tbsp plain flour
1½ quarts (1½ liters) hot beef stock
4 tbsp brandy
8 croûtes (see p39)
1 garlic clove, cut in half
4oz (115g) Gruyère or Emmental, grated

1 Melt the butter with the oil in a large, heavy pan over low heat. Add the onions and sugar and turn to coat well. Season with salt and freshly ground black pepper, then press a piece of damp wax paper on top of the onions. Cook, uncovered, stirring occasionally, for 40 minutes or until they are a rich dark brown color. Make sure that they do not stick and burn.

2 Remove the wax paper and stir in the wine. Increase the heat to medium and stir for 5 minutes while the onions glaze. Sprinkle in the flour and stir for 2 minutes, then pour in the stock and bring to a boil. Reduce the heat to low, cover with a lid, and let simmer for 30 minutes. Taste and season with salt and freshly ground black pepper, if necessary.

3 Preheat the grill to its highest setting. Divide the soup among flameproof bowls and stir 1 tbsp of the brandy into each. Rub the croûtes with the cut garlic and place one in each bowl. Sprinkle with the cheese and grill for 2–3 minutes or until the cheese is bubbling and golden. Serve at once.